

TWISTY AND TURNY: *Race* is a study in brand placement



film review

Fast Cars, Faster Women, Slow Burn

RACE

Directed by: Abbas-Mustan

Starring: Saif Ali Khan, Bipasha Basu, Katrina Kaif, Anil Kapoor, Akshaye Khanna, Sameera Reddy

As a sensory experience, *Race* is tough to beat. The women look piping hot, Bipasha in her Cleopatra eye make-up and Katrina in her always-one-size-too-small shirts. The men look tanned, and insist on calling every grown woman baby. Everyone has a deep, dark secret. Abbas-Mustan are the masters of cheap thrills and here they have producers who've tried to make them chic, giving them Bollywood's premier stylist, Anaita Shroff Adajania. She does her job well. From Saif Ali Khan's gold Rolex watch to Bipasha Basu's Dior glasses. From Katrina Kaif's Fendi bag to Anil Kapoor's YSL trousers, *Race* is a study in brand placement.

Yes, money can buy class. But only up to a point. There are lots of Porsches, Audis and Mercedes convertibles. And they have a tendency to blow up at key points in the movie. Fast cars and faster women is a heady cocktail that the *Dhoom* franchise first discovered. Unfortunately, *Race* doesn't have the franchise's wit, which flew from Vijay Krishna Acharya's often-sardonic pen. What it has instead is a succession of actors pouting into the camera, which is permanently placed in a low rise position in all the songs featuring back-up dancers of exotic nationalities. It also has dialogue that goes like this: "*Jo admi bahut hasta hai, woh bahut rota bhi hai* (The person who

laughs a lot also cries a lot)." Of course, the good Winchester boy that he is, Saif manages to sound urbane even while delivering such clunkers, but Anil Kapoor—who eats his way through a series of fruits in a long running gag—is not so lucky.

There's nothing the directors don't do to keep the audience in the hall. Saif regularly leaps off buildings, Bipasha generously allows a choreographed bedroom—albeit set in the stables—scene, and the colour coordinated songs just keep coming. But after a while, when the twists and turns get too twisty and turny (there is a murder, which is not a murder, but no one knows who the killer is), the peripherals take up too much attention. Isn't there too much hair on Akshaye Khanna's chest (ugh)? And aren't Saif's cheeks a little too pink (perchance to match his shirts)? Hmm.

by Kaveer Bamzai

art Sheer Simplicity

KOLKATA Amitabha Banerjee is known for bringing about a blissful marriage between technique and creativity in his prints. While most of his contemporaries made painting their first love, for Bangladesh-born Banerjee, prints came first, though his paintings are striking works in themselves. He combines technical brilliance with subtle use of tones, depth, texture, light and shade, and brilliant use of colour. The subjects for his prints have usually been simple—



Sarkar's subjects are simple

trees, plants, shrubs, brick walls, birds, butterflies and human figures. Lines and tones play an important part in his images in tandem with sheer simplicity.

The peace of a lazy afternoon is brought about brilliantly in the *Afternoon Siesta* and *Through the Window*. The *Load* and *Dove* are paintings in mixed media on paper, while *The Bride* is a stunning acrylic on paper. The free-flowing *Winter in North Dakota* is a water colour on paper while *Musician I* is a sketch in ink on paper.

by Elora Sen